

ESSENTIAL

Visitor Visa (Subclass 600) Master Guide

The complete walkthrough - GTE, the electronic visa system, and FAQs

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

What the Visitor visa is - and isn't

The Visitor visa (subclass 600) covers several streams; this guide focuses on the Tourist stream, the route most people use for holidays or visiting family and friends. A separate Business Visitor stream covers short business activities, and other streams (Sponsored Family, Approved Destination Status) exist for specific circumstances. It's decided under the Migration Act 1958 and Migration Regulations 1994. It does not permit employment, and it doesn't cover study beyond a short, incidental course.

The process end to end

Step	What happens
1. Apply online	Complete the application through ImmiAccount, selecting the Tourist stream.
2. Pay the VAC	The Visa Application Charge, generally non-refundable regardless of outcome.
3. Health and character checks	Complete a health examination or provide a police certificate only if the department directs you to, based on your circumstances.
4. Submit documents	Upload financial and ties-to-home evidence - see the Document Checklist.
5. Decision	Most Tourist stream applications are decided on the written file, without an interview. Processing times vary by country and time of year - check current times on the department's website.
6. Get your visa	Australia's visa is fully electronic - there's no passport sticker. You'll get a grant notification confirming your conditions and validity.

Visa validity and length of stay

A granted Visitor visa is commonly valid for multiple entries over up to 12 months, though validity and the permitted length of each stay (commonly 3, 6, or 12 months) are decided by the case officer based on your circumstances - there's no single fixed figure that applies to everyone. Always check the specific conditions on your own grant notification rather than assuming a standard length.

Reciprocal Health Care Agreements

Unlike Schengen, Australia doesn't require travel medical insurance for every Visitor visa applicant. However, Australia has Reciprocal Health Care Agreements (RHCAs) with a number of countries, giving eligible visitors from those countries limited access to Medicare, Australia's public healthcare system, for essential treatment. If your country doesn't have an RHCA with Australia, or for anything beyond what an RHCA covers, private travel insurance is strongly advisable even though it isn't a formal visa requirement for most applicants.

Frequently asked questions

Can I work on a Tourist stream visa?

No - the Tourist stream doesn't permit employment. Short, incidental business activities fall under the separate Business Visitor stream instead, and neither permits taking up a role in the Australian labour market.

Do I need a visa label to travel?

No - Australia's visa system is entirely electronic. Airlines and Australian border officials check your visa against your passport number directly; there's nothing physical to present beyond your passport itself.

What if I'm refused?

See the Refusal Decision Guide (Premium tier) for what review options (if any) apply and how to approach reapplying.